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Google Acquires Nest – Inching Towards the Home of the Future



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By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

These days, it seems consumer product innovation just boils down to major corporations unloading boatloads of cash and stock to buy the ideas from innovators. The unfortunate byproduct of this process crushes the potential for much competition in the marketplace.

Let's say, for example, Apple sees a potential need to include a thumb print scanner on

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the iPhone. Apple doesn't need to spend years to research and develop a proprietary solution. They take a \$356 million shortcut and just [absorb AuthenTec](#), a Melbourne, Florida-based security systems development company. This acquisition cuts Apple's immediate R&D costs down to zero and grants the computing giant a shiny new bullet point on the box of their newest iPhone.



Or perhaps when Google wanted to get into the phone hardware business, they did what has now become the current standard of tech giants. They decided to buy the largest phone manufacturer they can afford. In this case, they [snapped up Motorola Mobility](#). For a cool \$12.5 billion, Google banked on the prowess of Motorola's Mobility division, the once industry-leading phone manufacturer based in Libertyville, Illinois.

Apple's gamble paid off. It successfully incorporated AuthenTec's technology into its existing hardware. Google's gamble, however, fell short of expectations. The new Google flagship phone, the Moto X failed to find its footing in the hyper saturated smartphone market. Google licked its wounds and unloaded Motorola for a [hubristically painful \\$9.6 billion loss](#). Google's only response to that massive hit was that it acquired a mountain of patents in the deal.

So it might come as a surprise to see Google looking to buy another hardware manufacturer for another multi-billion-dollar sum mere weeks after the very public loss it suffered while unloading Motorola Mobility. But, we live in the age when the world's largest companies have bottomless pockets. So, [Google purchased Nest Labs for a massive pile of cash](#): \$3.2 billion.

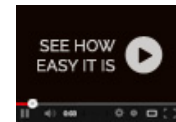
Doesn't Nest Just Make Thermostats?

Nest makes thermostats and smoke detectors, but calling a Nest thermostat just a thermostat is just like calling the iPod just a portable music player. The devil is in the details, and these thermostats function on a separate paradigm than something that just allows homeowners to control the temperature in each room.

These are intelligent learning devices that grow to anticipate your habits. This makes the product appetizing for homeowners hoping to save on heating costs and potentially use that savings to pay down

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This also makes the company appetizing to the tech industry's leading data collector.

But it may not just be the prospect of data collection from each Nest device that made Google shell out billions mere weeks after taking such a devastating loss from the Motorola sale.

The functionality of the product is important, vital even. But what's even more surprising is who comes along with this purchase.

The co-founder and CEO of Nest is none other than Tony Fadell, the man who led the team behind the concept and initial design of both the iPod and iPhone. Fadell served as Apple's senior vice president of iPod engineering during one of the most explosive periods of Apple's corporate growth.

So while the acquisition of Nest might seem bizarre for a search engine, it makes perfect sense to snag one of the most important Apple visionaries. Since it seems even Google doesn't have the pocketbook to buy out Apple, it was at least able to snag one of the greatest Apple alumni!

Normally these multi-billion-dollar buyouts include the not-so-specific fine print of "thanks for your shiny toys, now go quietly live out your days on a beach somewhere, we'll take it from here."



But, it seems in this case Fadell is keen to stay in the driver's seat.

Even after a life changing amount of money got plunked down in his lap, Fadell is insistent on continuing his work. "I don't want to retire. I want to build this vision. I set out to build this vision over the last decade. We're only three and a half years into this. I'm ready to go the whole way," he said in a recent interview with [theverge.com](#).

Fadell sat down with CNN Money tech correspondent Laurie Segall and discussed his products and philosophies:

DLD14- Clipping Leaving the Nest (Tony Fadell, Laurie Seg...



So, what does this mean for the home of the future?

In the most practical sense, those who decide to take the plunge with a Nest thermostat will soon provide the big G with a mountain of metrics about their day to day lives. How Google hopes to use all this information still remains a mystery.

But this may also be a breath of fresh temperature-controlled air for homeowners who have been searching for additional ways to control their homes while they are away, and cut down on heating costs.

With these new smart home inventions, we are inching closer and closer to the House of Tomorrow that American animation director Tex Avery prophesized back in 1949.

[Tex Avery - House of Tomorrow 1949](#) from [TheLH79](#) on [Vimeo](#).

We might never get a pocket-sized expandable house or that automatic sandwich maker, but a surprising number of these wacky inventions have seen the light of day. Nest's learning thermostat is most certainly on that list.

Considering that in 1949 the Internet would not be built for a few more decades, it is remarkable how close some of Tex Avery's musings on the home of the future really were to reality.

Here's a more up-to-date glance at where we're headed using today's advancements in technology and the connectivity of all things in our home from the good people at [howstuffworks.com](#)

What is The Internet of Things?



We may still be years away from widespread adoption of this future home technology. But it's something of a slippery slope to think about a future where every appliance in our homes has connected intelligence. When everything around us is capable of communicating with each other, suddenly we might find the thermostat talking with the fridge and deciding that the homeowner has now become obsolete!

Bio

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**Chaz Wilke**

Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.



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